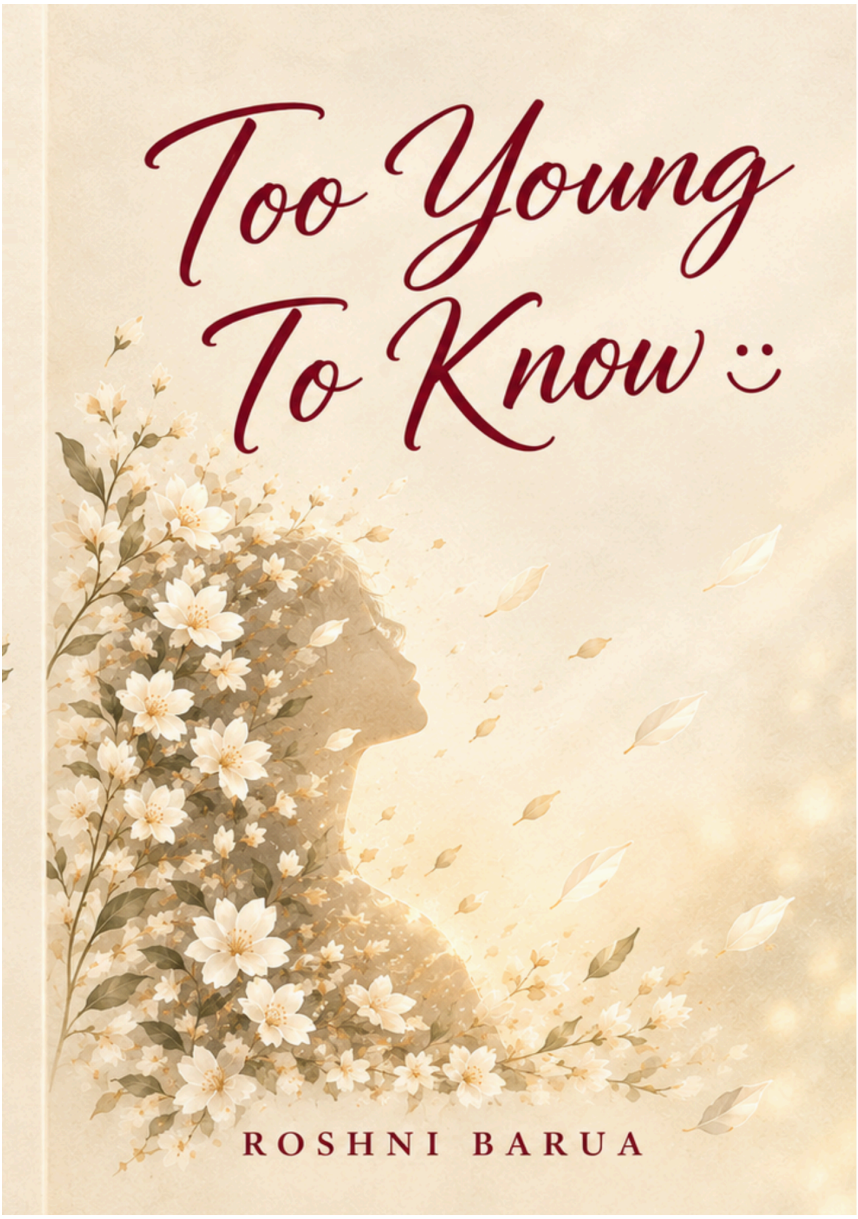


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Too Young
To Know

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TOO YOUNG TO KNOW

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I was too young to know what life would ask of me, but old enough to feel everything it did.

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Prologue

The story of a fresher doesn't begin with a job offer.
Sometimes, it begins on the last bench of a classroom—watching friends get placed, internships turn into careers, and everyone seemingly figure life out.
You smile for them.
Then you go home, open LinkedIn, and quietly wonder,
"When will it be my turn?"
Maybe you didn't get the job you wanted.
Maybe life didn't turn out the way you imagined.
Maybe you're just trying to understand who you are and where you're going.
Because growing up is strange.
We're expected to have answers when we're still learning the questions.
This isn't the story of someone who had it all figured out.
It's the story of someone still figuring it out.
Someone who chased dreams, carried expectations, lost a few things along the way

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and maybe, somewhere between growing up and letting go, loved someone who was never really theirs.

Maybe you.

Maybe me.

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I was too young to understand the weight of goodbye,
Too hopeful to know that some dreams pass us by.
I lost a little of myself while learning to grow,
And found a new me in the things I didn't know.

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PART I: THE BEAUTY COMMONLY SHARED

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Chapter 1

"From strangers to familiar faces."

There are some days in life that we don't realize are special until they become memories.

The first day of college is one of them.

For some, it begins with excitement. For others, it begins with fear. But for almost everyone, it begins with a question, some confussion

"What kind of life awaits me here?"

Freshly out of school, carrying dreams bigger than their bags, students walk through the gates of college with countless emotions. Some arrive with confidence, while others hide their nervousness behind a smile. Parents stand beside them, proud yet emotional, knowing that a new chapter is about to begin.

Everything feels unfamiliar.

New classrooms.

New teachers.

New surroundings.

And hundreds of unfamiliar faces.

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Everyone seems lost, yet everyone pretends to know where they are going.

Some students sit quietly in a corner, hoping nobody notices how nervous they are. Others start conversations that begin with the simplest questions:

"What's your name?"

"Where are you from?"

"Which branch are you in?"

Little do they know that these ordinary conversations are the beginning of extraordinary friendships.

The person sitting beside them today, a complete stranger, may one day become their closest friend.

Someone they will laugh with.

Someone they will celebrate victories with.

Someone they will call in the middle of the night before an exam.

And perhaps, someone they will miss for the rest of their lives.

College is strange in its own beautiful way.

Within a few days, unknown faces become familiar.

Within a few months, classmates become friends.

And within a few years, friends become family.

The first day is filled with awkward introductions, hesitant smiles, and silent observations. Everyone is trying to fit in. Everyone is trying to discover themselves.

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Some are excited about freedom.

No school uniforms.

No morning assemblies.

No strict rules.

For the first time, life feels different.

There is a sense of independence, and with that independence comes endless possibilities.

Everyone enters college carrying dreams.

Some dream of becoming engineers.

Some dream of becoming entrepreneurs.

Some dream of making their parents proud.

And some simply dream of finding themselves.

Nobody knows what the next four years hold.

Nobody knows who will remain together and who will eventually drift apart.

Nobody knows whose dreams will change and whose dreams will come true.

But that uncertainty is what makes the journey beautiful.

Years later, when life becomes busy and responsibilities replace carefree days, many will look back and smile.

Not because college was perfect.

But because it was the beginning.

The beginning of dreams.

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The beginning of friendships.
The beginning of memories.
And the beginning of a journey that would change them forever.
Because sometimes, the most beautiful stories begin with a room full of strangers.

When I walked into college for the induction program, I wasn't alone. By a strange coincidence, one of my school acquaintances had ended up taking admission in the same college. When we discovered that we would be spending the next four years under the same roof, we simply said,
"Well, let's attend the induction program together."
Honestly, college didn't feel particularly special to me on the first day.
I thought to myself, *"Just like school passed by, college will pass by too."*
I wasn't looking for a large circle of friends. After all, throughout my school life, I had only one true friend. In fact, in my entire school journey, that one person was all I ever needed.
So I entered college with no expectations.
No plans of making countless memories.
No dreams of having a huge group of friends.
Little did I know that life had other plans.
Our induction program lasted for twenty-one days.
And during those twenty-one days, something beautiful happened.

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A leader emerged among us, someone who unknowingly brought a group of strangers together. Slowly, our little circle grew bigger, and before we realized it, we had become the largest friend group in the entire college.

We proudly called ourselves **"Our Family."**

Soon, everyone knew about us.

People talked about us.

And somehow, our group became a small world of its own.

We bunked classes together.

Occasionally, we went to watch movies.

Without even realizing it, we picked up a few funny slangs and phrases from each other.

The funniest part was that some of the people I met on the very first day made me think,

"What a bunch of weird and cringe people!"

And today, those very people are among the most precious friends I have ever had.

In our group, all it took was one person to suggest bunking a class, and one by one, everyone would quietly disappear.

Sometimes, we would sit in the garden and play Truth and Dare, trying to know each other better.

Sometimes, we would gather in the canteen over plates of samosas and endless conversations.

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And sometimes, we would simply walk around the campus together, talking about everything and nothing at the same time.
There was something special about us.
Something beyond friendship.
There was unity.
There was trust.
And there was a sense of belonging.
We had entered college as strangers.
But somewhere during those twenty-one days, without even noticing, we had started becoming a family.
Perhaps that is the magic of college.
You don't walk in searching for memories.
Yet somehow, memories find you.
And the people you never expected to matter become the people you cannot imagine your life without.

What surprised me the most was how naturally we became a part of each other's everyday lives.
Back in school, I had never experienced this kind of bond with anyone. I had friends, but not the kind of friendship where people would wait for you, look for you, and somehow make even the smallest moments feel special.
In college, things were different.

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Not the whole group, of course, but little clusters within our "Our Family" group would do everything together.

Sometimes, two or three of us would go to refill our empty water bottles together.

Sometimes, we would accompany each other to the washroom, simply because nobody wanted to walk alone.

And somehow, these little moments became memories.

I still remember how we would be standing outside the washroom waiting for one friend. Suddenly, four more friends from the upper floor would come downstairs and ask,

"Hey, what's going on? Aren't we going to the canteen? Why are you all standing here?"

And when they found out that one person from our group had gone to the washroom, instead of leaving, they would simply say,

"Oh, okay. Let's wait."

And just like that, the number of people waiting would increase from two to six.

Looking back now, it sounds funny.

Who waits for someone outside a washroom?

But perhaps that was our way of saying,

"No one gets left behind."

And honestly, that was beautiful.

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There was a kind of unity among us that I had never experienced before.

We didn't need grand occasions to be happy.

Sometimes, happiness was simply sitting together in the canteen with samosas on the table.

Sometimes, it was walking around the campus with no destination in mind.

Sometimes, it was spending hours playing Truth and Dare in the garden, discovering each other's secrets and embarrassing stories.

And sometimes, it was doing absolutely nothing together.

Yet somehow, those moments meant everything.

Then came the college fest season.

The excitement was unreal.

Months before the actual event, we had already started planning and, of course, finding reasons to bunk classes in the name of preparations.

There was an energy in the air.

Everyone wanted to participate.

Everyone wanted to contribute.

And what made it even more special was our seniors.

They never made us feel like juniors.

Not even once.

Instead of treating us differently, they treated us like friends.

They guided us, joked with us, and worked alongside us.

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Whether it was dance practice, event management, decorations, or simply sharing snacks during rehearsals, they made us feel like we truly belonged.

There was no awkward hierarchy.

No feeling of being left out.

They welcomed us with open arms and unknowingly became a part of some of our most cherished memories.

Perhaps that is the beauty of college.

You enter expecting classrooms and lectures.

But what you receive are friendships, laughter, shared secrets, endless memories, and people who slowly become a second family.

And before you realize it, you are no longer counting semesters.

You are collecting moments.

Moments that one day, years later, will make you smile and whisper to yourself,

"Those really were the best days."

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Chapter 2

Four Years in a Blink

"From strangers to friends, from friends to family."

People say time flies when you're having fun.

Perhaps that's why four years felt like four months.

Or maybe four weeks.

Because before we could even realize it, the same strangers who once sat awkwardly beside us had become our closest friends, and those friends had slowly become family.

School had taught us one thing about examinations.

Start preparing at least a week in advance.

But college had its own rules.

Those who used to study a week before exams in school slowly transformed into people who somehow managed to pass by studying just one night before the exam.

And strangely enough, everyone survived.

Semester after semester.

Assignment after assignment.

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Practical after practical.
Time slipped away.
Not in grand moments, but in ordinary days that eventually became extraordinary memories.
Exam season was a story in itself.
There was always that one friend.
The friend who would first study the entire syllabus alone and then become the unofficial professor for everyone else.
In front of that friend, YouTube tutorials, ChatGPT, Wikipedia, and even our college professors stood no chance.
That friend possessed magical powers.
Armed with rough notes, screenshots of handwritten pages, and explanations in pure Hinglish, they could simplify the most complicated subjects.
Hours-long Google Meet sessions became our classrooms.
Midnight video calls became our tuition classes.
There were endless playlists, countless voice notes, and discussions that often lasted until two or three in the morning.
And somehow, thanks to that one friend, we all passed.
Not with perfect grades.
But with unforgettable memories.

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Ironically, the same college management we constantly complained about and jokingly called "poor management" became the reason behind some of the happiest moments of our lives.

Because when annual fest season arrived, none of those complaints mattered.

We danced our hearts out.

We sang without caring about who was watching.

We cheered for our friends.

And for those few days, life felt perfect.

Looking back now, it is hard to believe that four years passed so quickly. Between semester exams, assignments, practical files, lectures, and endless bunks, time quietly slipped through our fingers.

Even the canteen held memories of its own.

In the scorching summer heat, we would gather there without fail.

Whenever something hot and crispy was being fried, the smoke would make everyone cough, and our throats would go dry.

Yet somehow, that never stopped us from eating.

One person would buy a packet of chips.

But the funny part was that the owner of the chips hardly managed to eat a single wafer.

The packet would travel through the entire group, and by the time it came back, it was almost empty.

No one complained.

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Because that's how friendship worked.
Lunch boxes were never personal belongings.
They belonged to everyone.
If someone forgot to bring lunch or didn't have anything to eat, nobody let them go hungry.
Instead, someone would immediately say,
"Why are you going to the canteen? Here, have my lunch."
And just like that, food became another language of love.
Perhaps the most amusing thing was that we were always the first ones to reach college and somehow the last ones to leave.
We would arrive early in the morning, have breakfast together, and then intentionally miss the first lecture.
Soon, a senior friend would appear and somehow escort everyone to the second lecture.
And by the time the last lecture came around, half the class had mysteriously vanished.
Sometimes, we would head to the library.
Not always to study.
More often than not, we went there to pretend to study.
And our beloved librarian knew it.
He knew that very little studying was actually happening.
Yet he never scolded us.

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Perhaps because he knew that beneath all the noise and mischief, we were good kids with good hearts.

There were festivals.

There were trips.

There were birthdays celebrated with cheap cakes and expensive emotions.

There were endless photographs and countless inside jokes.

There were teachers who became mentors.

Seniors who became friends.

And lessons that no textbook could ever teach.

Without realizing it, we learned how to trust people.

How to support each other.

How to celebrate someone else's happiness.

How to fail and rise again.

And most importantly, how to create a home away from home.

Because college was never just about degrees.

It was about the people.

The laughter between lectures.

The conversations after class.

The shared meals.

The sleepless nights before exams.

The memories hidden in every corner of the campus.

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And perhaps that is why, when people ask us about college, we rarely remember the marks we scored.

We remember the people.

Because marks fade with time.

But memories don't.

And before we knew it, four years had passed.

Not slowly.

Not gradually.

But in the blink of an eye.

And somewhere between attendance shortages, practical files, late-night study sessions, canteen samosas, library dramas, and endless laughter, strangers had become friends.

And friends had become family.

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Chapter 3

The Last Day

"Nobody told us it would be the last time."

Nobody warned us.

Nobody announced it.

Nobody said,

"Cherish this lecture. It will be your last."

"Take one more walk around the campus. You may never do it again."

"Laugh a little longer with your friends because one day these moments will become memories."

By the final year, college no longer looked the same.

Everyone was busy.

Some had internships to attend.

Some were preparing for placements.

Some were already executing the plans they had spent years dreaming about.

Placement season had arrived, and with it came responsibilities.

Slowly, the crowd in the classrooms became smaller.

Attendance no longer mattered.

Life outside the college gates had started calling us.

And perhaps that was why we never realized that we were slowly saying goodbye.

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Nobody told us that this was our last semester.
Nobody told us that these were our last internal exams.
Nobody told us that these practical files we complained about for four years would soon become things we would laugh about.
Semester after semester, exam after exam, assignment after assignment...
And before we knew it, even the last semester had come to an end.
For our final practical day, someone suggested celebrating Scribble Day.
Everyone had brought white T-shirts.
But strangely, nobody wore them.
Perhaps, for the first time, we had fallen in love with our college uniform.
The same grey T-shirt that we used to jokingly call a "jute sack."
The same uniform we complained about for four years.
And yet, on that day, it felt more valuable than any branded outfit.
It felt priceless.
As soon as the last practical ended, everyone took out their black markers.
In bold letters, right in the middle of our grey T-shirts, we wrote:
BATCH 2022–2026
Suddenly, the empty T-shirt became a canvas of memories.
One by one, our closest friends came forward.

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And slowly, the blank spaces began to disappear.

Someone wrote:

"Will miss you."

Someone else wrote:

"Best Friend."

Another friend smiled and wrote:

"Brother from another mother."

One of them wrote:

"Generator wali hasi."

And someone quietly added:

"Best Wishes."

A friend brought acrylic paints and drew a tiny little heart on the shirt.

It wasn't perfect.

But then again, neither were we.

And perhaps that was what made it beautiful.

Soon, everyone's shirts were filled with names, inside jokes, signatures, funny drawings, and messages that only we could understand.

And somewhere between all the laughter and teasing, silence slowly started creeping in.

Because for the first time, it hit us.

This was it.

No more attendance shortages.

No more assignments submitted at the last minute.

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No more canteen samosas.

No more bunk plans.

No more waiting outside the washroom for that one friend.

No more pretending to study in the library.

No more Google Meet study sessions at midnight.

No more shouting across the corridor to call someone to class.

No more festivals.

No more ordinary days that had secretly become extraordinary.

We took hundreds of photographs.

Group photos.

Silly photos.

Blurred photos.

Photos that captured smiles without realizing they were preserving memories.

And like everyone else, we made promises.

"We'll stay in touch."

"Let's plan trips every year."

"Nothing will change between us."

And perhaps we all meant those words.

Because at that moment, we truly believed them.

But life has a strange way of moving people in different directions.

Some friends would move to different cities.

Some would chase dreams abroad.

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Some would get busy with jobs.
Some would become strangers again.
And a few...
A very few...
Would remain family forever.
As the sun began to set, we walked out of the campus gates together.
Not knowing that this would be the last time we would leave as students.
No farewell speech could prepare us.
No photograph could capture everything.
No words could describe the feeling.
Because nobody told us that it would be the last time.
Nobody told us that one day we would miss even the things we once complained about.
And perhaps that is the cruelest and most beautiful truth about life.
Sometimes, the moments that change us forever don't announce their arrival.
And they certainly don't announce their end.
They simply become memories.
And one day, years later, you stumble upon an old grey T-shirt hidden somewhere in your cupboard.
You read the faded words written in black marker.
You smile.

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And for a brief moment...

You are twenty years old again.

And then came the hardest part.

The goodbyes.

That day, everyone cried.

Not just a few tears.

We cried a lot.

We hugged each other tightly.

We comforted one another while trying to hide our own tears.

Some of us even cried while hugging classmates with whom we had barely spoken more than eight times in four years.

Maybe we had only talked whenever we needed notes or some help with assignments.

Yet somehow, at that moment, none of that mattered.

Because we had spent four years growing up together.

And that alone was enough.

Someone hosted one final batch party.

Everyone danced their hearts out.

There was laughter.

There were photographs.

There were songs that we knew would someday remind us of these very moments.

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And when the party ended, everyone was in the same condition as on Scribble Day.

We cried.

Again.

Perhaps because somewhere along the way, we had built a family.

And now, for the first time, we realized that we wouldn't get to meet that family every day anymore.

There was a strange heaviness in our hearts.

As if someone had placed a stone inside our chest.

We smiled.

But our eyes told a different story.

On Scribble Day, we also went to meet our teachers.

The same teachers who had scolded us countless times.

The same teachers whose lectures we had secretly escaped from.

And surprisingly, they were emotional too.

Some of them smiled and asked,

"You'll remember us, won't you?"

Those simple words were enough to bring tears to our eyes.

Then something unexpected happened.

They started telling us about ourselves.

About the qualities they had noticed during lectures.

About the strengths we never knew we had.

Some spoke about leadership.

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Some appreciated our kindness.
Some admired our curiosity.
And suddenly, we realized that while we were busy counting attendance and waiting for lectures to end, they had been silently watching us grow.
They wrote messages on our T-shirts.
Signed their names.
And blessed us with words that meant more than marks ever could.
"Best wishes."
"Keep shining."
"Make us proud."
"Never stop learning."
But perhaps the most unforgettable moment came when we went to meet the librarian.
The same librarian who had watched us enter the library every day.
The same librarian who knew very well that we spent more time pretending to study than actually studying.
As we walked towards him, he looked at us and said with a smile,
"I was waiting for you all to come. And only now have you finally arrived."
That sentence broke something inside us.
The tears that we had been holding back finally escaped.
Because suddenly, we understood.

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He had been waiting to say goodbye.

As our eyes wandered around the library, they stopped at those familiar tables.

Those same tables where we had spent hours pretending to study.

Those same chairs where we had sometimes actually studied.

Those same corners where laughter, stress, friendships, and dreams had lived together.

And suddenly, our throats tightened.

There were too many memories.

Uncountable memories.

Memories of assignments completed at the last minute.

Memories of sleeping over books.

Memories of sharing jokes when we were supposed to be silent.

Memories of helping each other before exams.

Memories hidden in every table, every corridor, every classroom, every staircase.

Every corner of the campus held a story.

And every story held a piece of us.

Looking back now, I realize something.

We thought we were merely studying for a degree.

But college was doing something far greater.

It was teaching us how to love people.

How to laugh.

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How to fail.

How to support each other.

How to say goodbye.

And perhaps, that is why leaving college hurts so much.

Not because we miss the assignments.

Not because we miss the lectures.

But because we leave behind a version of ourselves that will never exist again.

And as we walked out of those gates one final time, none of us knew what the future held.

But we knew one thing.

We entered as strangers.

We became friends.

And somewhere between attendance shortages, canteen samosas, sleepless nights, Scribble Days, and tearful goodbyes...

We became family.

And families, no matter how far apart they are, never truly say goodbye.

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PART II: THE BIRTH OF A FRESHER

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Chapter 4

Welcome to Reality

"Degree in hand, uncertainty in mind."

For four years, life had a rhythm.

Lectures.

Assignments.

Semester exams.

Festivals.

Friendships.

And somehow, without realizing it, college had become more than just a place.

It had become a roof above our heads.

As long as college existed, there was comfort in knowing that life had a structure.

Even if things weren't perfect, there was always tomorrow.

Tomorrow's lecture.

Tomorrow's practical.

Tomorrow's attendance shortage.

Tomorrow's canteen plans.

But the day college ended, something else disappeared with it.

The roof.

Suddenly, there were no timetables.

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No teachers reminding us of deadlines.

No semesters to divide life into manageable pieces.

No next academic year waiting around the corner.

For the first time, life stood in front of us and asked a question that had no answer sheet.

"What next?"

The degree was finally in our hands.

But so was uncertainty.

Everyone had dreams.

Some wanted jobs.

Some wanted higher studies.

Some wanted to start businesses.

And some, if they were honest, had absolutely no idea what they wanted.

And that was okay.

Because nobody really teaches us how strange life feels after graduation.

In college, we believed that getting a degree would be enough.

But reality had changed.

The world had changed.

And so had the job market.

Skills that were never taught inside classrooms had suddenly become requirements.

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Communication.

Networking.

Problem-solving.

Personal branding.

Adaptability.

Practical experience.

The market wasn't asking only what we had studied.

It was asking what we could do.

And that realization was terrifying.

Many freshers discovered that the world outside college was different from what they had imagined.

Expectations met reality.

And reality was not always kind.

Some found jobs immediately.

Some found internships.

And some found rejection.

But perhaps the greatest challenge was not competition.

It was confusion.

Because for the first time in life, nobody could tell us what chapter came next.

And if there is one thing I wish every college student knew, it is this:

Don't spend all four years running after one destination.

Spend the first year or two truly living.

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Enjoy college.

Explore different fields.

Try things.

Fail at things.

Discover what excites you.

Because there is no prize for figuring out life at nineteen.

Take your time.

And once you finally realize what you want...

Go after it wholeheartedly.

Improve your skills.

Become shameless in the pursuit of growth.

Reach out to people.

Send messages.

Ask questions.

Make phone calls if necessary.

Seek guidance.

Because opportunities rarely knock on closed doors.

And remember,

No one hands out medals for suffering in silence.

Work on your communication.

Learn to express yourself.

Learn to speak confidently.

Learn to ask for help.

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Because talent hidden in silence often goes unnoticed.

The world rewards people who show up.

And perhaps that is the biggest difference between college and real life.

In college, marks could speak for you.

Outside college, you must learn to speak for yourself.

Yes, the competition is increasing.

Yes, technology is changing.

Yes, the world is demanding more than ever before.

But remember this.

No one is born ready.

Every professional was once a fresher.

Every expert was once confused.

Every successful person once stood exactly where you are standing now.

With a degree in hand.

And uncertainty in mind.

Because becoming a fresher is strange.

One day, you are discussing attendance shortages with your friends.

And the next day, you are updating your resume and wondering whether your skills are enough.

One day, you are laughing in the canteen.

And the next day, you are searching for jobs and refreshing your inbox.

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Life changes quickly.

But perhaps that is not something to fear.

Perhaps it is something to embrace.

Because after all...

College gave us memories.

But life after college gives us something even greater.

A chance to discover who we truly are.

And that is where the story of a young fresher truly begins.

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Chapter 5

LinkedIn and the Silent Battles

"Congratulations to others, questions for ourselves."

There comes a point in every fresher's journey when the biggest competition is no longer the job market.

It is the mind.

And strangely enough, sometimes that battle begins with a simple notification.

"Proud to announce..."

"Excited to share..."

"Thrilled to inform..."

And suddenly, another success story appears on the screen.

Someone got an internship.

Someone completed a certification.

Someone built a project.

Someone received an offer letter.

And while we genuinely feel happy for them, somewhere deep inside, another voice quietly asks:

"What have I achieved?"

"Am I not good enough?"

"Why does everyone seem to be moving forward except me?"

Perhaps half of our fear comes not from reality, but from what we see.

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Imagine if we started posting our everyday life with the same enthusiasm.

Proud to announce that I have successfully completed the comprehensive cleaning and organization of my home.
This challenging project involved dust management, surface optimization, waste disposal, and strategic space reorganization.
Key Outcomes:

- Cleaner environment.
- Better productivity.
- Enhanced peace of mind.

Looking forward to leveraging these skills in future household operations.
#AchievementUnlocked #Productivity #HomeManagement #ContinuousImprovement

Honestly, who wouldn't be intimidated after reading something like that?
Suddenly, sweeping the floor sounds like a Fortune 500 project.
And that is exactly how social media works.
Half the fear comes from seeing someone else's achievements and thinking,

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"Look at them. They have accomplished so much, and all I've done so far is sweep the floor."

"Their profile satisfies every requirement. Mine probably doesn't."

"Maybe something is wrong with me."

But here's something worth remembering.

Both people did the same work.

Perhaps the broom was different.

But the real difference lies in how loudly and confidently they expressed it.

REMEMBER: NEVER BE AFRAID OF SOMEONE ELSE'S HYPE.

Never.

Because success is not measured by how grandly it is presented.

And life is not a competition of LinkedIn posts.

Never compare yourself to someone else's highlight reel.

Someone may proudly announce that they have completed ten certifications.

But who knows?

Perhaps they skipped every module and only posted the completion certificate.

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Someone else may have zero posts, yet possess years of practical experience.
One person may look successful online while silently struggling behind the scenes.
Another person may appear invisible online while quietly building something extraordinary.
Social media shows outcomes.
It rarely shows the process.
And sometimes, yes, jealousy happens.
We're human.
Seeing someone else's success can make us uncomfortable.
But remember, maybe they truly worked hard.
Maybe they sacrificed sleep.
Maybe they faced rejection after rejection.
Maybe they failed countless times before finally posting that one achievement.
Because they posted the success.
They didn't post the failures.
Think about it.
How many times must they have fallen?
How many times must they have doubted themselves?
How many nights must they have spent wondering if they should give up?

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You never know someone's backstory.

And that is why it is unfair to compare your Chapter 1 with someone else's Chapter 20.

Instead of feeling threatened by someone else's success, celebrate it.

Learn from it.

Reach out.

Ask for guidance.

Because perhaps next time, you will be the one inspiring someone else.

Think about it.

Someone successfully built a project.

And while they probably spent weeks debugging, learning, and struggling, we sometimes enter self-doubt after seeing their post.

We become jealous.

We start questioning ourselves.

And then, the moment our own code throws an error, we shut down the laptop and say,

"That's enough. I'll deal with it tomorrow."

But success doesn't work that way.

Behind every successful project are countless errors.

Behind every offer letter are dozens of rejections.

Behind every promotion are years of effort.

Behind every confident person is someone who once had no idea what they were doing.

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Every success has a struggle hidden behind it.

Do not fear the struggle.

Learn from it.

Use your difficult days in your favor.

Because bad times are not punishments.

They are preparations.

They teach patience.

They teach discipline.

They teach resilience.

And perhaps that is why the people who struggle the most often appreciate success the most.

Always be happy for others.

Because another person's success does not reduce your chances.

The sky is big enough for everyone.

And one day, when your time comes, someone else might be looking at your post and wondering,

"How did they do it?"

Little will they know that behind that one post were sleepless nights, failures, doubts, tears, and a thousand moments when you almost gave up.

Because every success story has chapters that the world never gets to read.

And perhaps that is the greatest lesson a young fresher can learn.

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Don't be afraid of someone's success.

Don't be jealous of someone's journey.

Don't compare your pace with theirs.

And above all...

Never be afraid of someone else's hype.

Because hype fades.

But growth remains.

And while the world may celebrate outcomes,

Life quietly rewards those who continue showing up, even when nobody is watching.

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Chapter 6

Random Thoughts at 2 A.M.

"Am I late? Did I choose the wrong path?"

There is something strange about two in the morning.

Problems that seem manageable during the day suddenly become life-threatening.

Dreams become doubts.

Hope becomes fear.

And the mind, which remained silent all day, suddenly decides that now is the perfect time to conduct a full investigation of your life.

Everyone sleeps.

But the thoughts don't.

"What am I doing with my life?"

"Am I too late?"

"Did I choose the wrong field?"

"What if I fail?"

"What if everyone else succeeds and I don't?"

"Am I wasting my time?"

"What if I never become successful?"

"Will my parents be proud of me?"

"Will I ever make it?"

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And somehow, by 2:30 A.M., your mind has already imagined yourself unemployed at forty, broke, disappointing everyone around you, and regretting every decision you ever made.

The human mind is talented.

Especially when it comes to creating problems that don't even exist.

It makes us fail in situations we haven't faced yet.

It convinces us that one bad day means a bad life.

And sometimes, it mistakes uncertainty for failure.

But perhaps the truth is much simpler.

Growing up is confusing.

Nobody has all the answers.

Not at twenty-two.

Not at thirty.

Not even at fifty.

Everyone is figuring things out.

Some people just look more confident while doing it.

One of the greatest lies we tell ourselves is:

"I should have figured everything out by now."

Says who?

Life never gave us a deadline.

And success never promised to arrive at a certain age.

Some people discover their passion early.

Some change their path halfway through life.

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Some spend years searching before finally understanding themselves.

And none of them are wrong.

Because there is no universal timeline.

There are only individual journeys.

The problem begins when we measure our lives using someone else's clock.

We see people buying cars.

Getting jobs.

Starting businesses.

Moving abroad.

Getting married.

And suddenly, without even realizing it, we start believing that life is a race.

But races have a common finish line.

Life doesn't.

Not everyone is trying to reach the same destination.

Perhaps the person earning more than you secretly wishes they had your freedom.

Perhaps the person who seems successful is fighting battles you know nothing about.

Perhaps the person who appears "ahead" is simply walking a different road.

And perhaps...

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you are exactly where you need to be.

Because not every delay is a punishment.

Sometimes, delays are preparation.

Sometimes, life takes time because it is building something stronger.

A tree does not become weak because it takes years to grow.

Mountains are not formed overnight.

And neither are people.

Know Yourself Before Comparing Yourself

Before comparing yourself with someone else, ask yourself a simple question:

"Do I even want what they have?"

Sometimes, we don't envy people.

We envy the applause they receive.

And there is a difference.

Understand yourself first.

Understand your dreams.

Understand your strengths.

Understand what kind of life makes you happy.

Because success without peace is just another form of exhaustion.

And peace without purpose eventually becomes emptiness.

Find your balance.

Create your own definition of success.

And then walk towards it with patience.

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Because success has different timelines.

Some stories begin early.

Some stories begin late.

But every story unfolds at its own pace.

A flower blooming in December is not late because another flower bloomed in April.

They simply belong to different seasons.

And perhaps the answer to those random thoughts at two in the morning is this:

No.

You are not behind.

No.

You are not running out of time.

No.

You haven't ruined your future.

You are simply becoming.

And becoming one takes time.

So the next time your mind starts asking impossible questions in the middle of the night, smile and remind yourself:

"I don't need to have everything figured out today."

Because sometimes, the bravest thing a person can do is trust that the pieces will eventually fall into place.

And until then...

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Keep going.

Even if you don't know where the road ends.

Because not knowing the destination doesn't mean you're lost.

Sometimes,

it simply means you're still discovering who you're meant to become.

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PART III: PRESSURES WE NEVER TALK ABOUT

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Chapter 7

Family Expectations

"Beta, job kab lagegi?"

There are some questions that almost every fresher hears.

"Beta, job kab lagegi?"

"Ab aage kya socha hai?"

"Uska toh lag gaya, tumhara kab lagega?"

And perhaps the most dangerous sentence of all:

"Sharma ji ke bete ka toh..."

These questions are rarely asked with bad intentions.

Parents worry.

Relatives compare.

Society observes.

And somewhere between love, expectations, and social pressure, a young person finds themselves carrying a burden they never learned how to explain.

Because growing up is expensive.

Dreams are expensive.

And uncertainty is exhausting.

The pressure becomes even heavier when you're living away from home.

In a different city.

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Preparing for jobs.

Trying to build a future.

Perhaps working part-time to manage expenses.

Perhaps taking money from your parents every month.

And sometimes, asking for money hurts more than not having money.

You stare at your phone for ten minutes before calling home.

You think twice before asking.

You tell yourself,

"I'll manage somehow."

Because at some point, every child dreams of becoming a support system for their parents.

Not another responsibility.

And that feeling...

That silent guilt...

Nobody talks about it.

For young men, the pressure often comes disguised as responsibility.

"You have to earn."

"You have to provide."

"You have to take care of everyone."

And somewhere along the way, they are taught that asking for help is weakness.

That struggling should be hidden.

That emotions should be swallowed.

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That they must have everything figured out.

For young women, the questions are often different.

"Job toh theek hai, but marriage kab?"

"How long will you study?"

"Beta, age bhi toh ho rahi hai."

"Career important hai, lekin ghar bhi sambhalna hai."

And suddenly, dreams are forced to compete with expectations.

Both carry pressure.

Different pressures.

But pressure nonetheless.

And perhaps what hurts the most is not failure.

It is a comparison.

People will talk.

They always will.

If you're unemployed, they will talk.

If you're preparing, they will talk.

If you change your career path, they will talk.

And if you're working outside your degree, they will definitely talk.

Imagine someone with a technical degree taking a non-technical job to survive and support themselves.

Immediately, some people will say:

"So much money was spent on the degree, and now look, doing a job that even a twelfth-pass person can do."

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But tell me something.

When there is no water in your house during summer, will those people arrange a water tanker for your family?

Will they bring groceries to your home?

Will they buy your mother her favorite cake on her birthday?

Will they pay your bills?

Will they fulfill your dreams?

No.

Because opinions are free.

Responsibilities are not.

And there is absolutely no shame in honest work.

None.

Work is work.

Effort is effort.

Survival is survival.

And dignity does not depend on job titles.

Never feel embarrassed for doing what you must while working toward what you want.

Because life is not a movie.

Sometimes dreams are built slowly.

Sometimes they are funded by part-time jobs.

Sometimes they are supported by sacrifices nobody else sees.

And there is nothing shameful about that.

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Do what you do with confidence.

Because it is your life.

Live it according to your values.

Not according to somebody else's expectations.

After all, while society is busy comparing you with Sharma Ji's son, perhaps Sharma Ji's son himself is sitting at home with a degree and wondering what to do next.

Everyone is fighting battles.

Everyone is carrying expectations.

Everyone is trying to survive.

So stop living your life for spectators.

Spectators only watch.

They don't participate.

And remember this:

Success doesn't care whether you started with a dream job or a temporary job.

Success only cares that you kept moving.

There is no shame in earning.

There is no shame in starting small.

There is no shame in changing directions.

There is no shame in taking time.

The only shame would be giving up because of people who contribute nothing to your journey.

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One day, your parents won't remember how long it took.

They won't remember your starting salary.

They won't remember what relatives said.

They will simply remember that despite all the difficulties, despite all the uncertainties, despite all the pressure...

You kept going.

And perhaps that is what truly makes them proud.

Not perfection.

Not speed.

But perseverance.

Because at the end of the day, life is not about proving yourself to society.

It is about creating a life that lets you sleep peacefully.

And no amount of comparison can compete with peace.

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Chapter 8

Losing Yourself

"When the things you once loved slowly disappear."

Growing up doesn't always mean losing people.

Sometimes, it means losing pieces of yourself.

Not suddenly.

Not dramatically.

But quietly.

So quietly that one day you wake up and realize that the things which once made your eyes light up have become strangers to you.

I loved dancing.

But one day, my father casually said,

"You can do that later."

I loved colors.

There was something magical about creating life on a blank canvas.

But then a distant uncle said,

"My neighbor's son also followed this path, and look how he failed."

As if someone else's story had already decided mine.

I once brought home a guitar with excitement.

I imagined learning songs and spending evenings with melodies.

But then another thought arrived.

"What if everyone finds it noisy?"

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"Let me keep it aside for now."

And "for now" quietly became years.

There is always a reason.

"First, let me get a job."

"First, let me become financially independent."

"First, let me settle down."

And before we realize it, our dreams have become appointments scheduled for "someday."

But someday is a dangerous word.

Because someday often turns into never.

Then life gives you what you wanted.

The job finally arrives.

And suddenly, a new set of excuses replaces the old ones.

Ten to seven office hours.

An hour of travelling.

Cooking.

Household responsibilities.

Deadlines.

Targets.

Salary hikes.

And just when you think life will become easier, new worries arrive dressed in different clothes.

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And somewhere in this endless cycle, the things that once made you feel alive...

Disappear.

As if they never existed.

One of my friends loved modelling.

Not because he wanted fame.

But because it taught him confidence.

It made him conscious of his posture, his gestures, and the way he carried himself.

It made him believe in himself a little more.

And perhaps that is the beauty of the things we love.

They are not distractions.

They shape us.

They heal us.

They remind us who we are.

Imagine how beautiful life would be if we allowed ourselves to carry these passions along with our responsibilities.

Perhaps you would have remained energetic.

Perhaps your mind would have stayed creative.

Perhaps your heart would have remained peaceful.

Perhaps stress would have had less power over you.

Instead, we spend our unemployed days worrying.

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And when we finally start earning, we discover that time itself has become expensive.

Back then, there was anxiety about the future.

Now, there is anxiety about appraisals, promotions, and salary hikes.

The worries change.

But worries never leave.

And suddenly, one day, guilt arrives.

The guilt of all the things you wanted to do but never did.

Ironically, society calls this sacrifice.

People admire you.

They say,

"Look how serious they are."

"They gave up everything for their career."

"What dedication!"

And perhaps, in their eyes, you become great.

But think about the next generation.

What about the children who want to build a life where passion and profession walk together?

Who will inspire them?

Who will prove that dreams and responsibilities are not enemies?

Who will make sure that someday no distant uncle can confidently declare,

"My neighbor failed because of his passion."

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Because passions do not make people fail.

Fear does.

Comparison does.

Giving up on ourselves does.

Enjoy Your Unemployment

People treat unemployment like a punishment.

Perhaps it isn't.

Perhaps it is a gift disguised as uncertainty.

A rare phase where you still have time.

Time to rest.

Time to learn.

Time to spend with your parents, to understand them how much they love you when you have nothing to give them....

Time to laugh with your siblings, when they know that you can’t buy them their favourite playstation

Time to discover parts of yourself that responsibilities haven't taken away yet.

Rest .....

You are not wasting your life because you took a break.

You are not lazy because you slept during afternoon.

You are human.

And humans are not machines.

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And if travelling is something you love but money is limited, who says adventures have to be expensive?

Who says you need flights and luxury hotels?

Explore the hidden gems around you.

Visit that park you always ignored.

Watch sunsets.

Go on morning walks.

Take photographs.

Collect memories.

Because joy doesn't always demand money.

Sometimes, it only asks for attention.

Work hard.

Study sincerely.

Build your career.

Earn well.

But please...

Never kill your desires.

Never bury your dreams.

Never abandon the parts of yourself that make life beautiful.

Because your career will give you money.

But the things you love will teach you how to live.

Don't lose yourself in the race.

The world will constantly ask you to become more.

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But in the process, do not forget who you already are.

Be the one who you are, because that is what makes you unique.

The world doesn't need another copy.

It needs you.

The version of you that dreams.

The version of you that smiles.

The version of you that feels alive.

Protect that person.

Because success can be rebuilt.

Money can be earned again.

But if you lose yourself completely, finding your way back becomes much harder.

And perhaps that is what success truly means.

Not reaching a destination.

But arriving there without leaving yourself behind.

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LETTER TO MYSELF

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LETTER - 01
ON THE DAY BANARAS MADE MY PROBLEMS FEEL SMALL

I was genuinely happy that day.
I had dressed well—maybe a little too well for a simple boat ride—but I didn't care. **Finally, Banaras.**
For days, I had been waiting for this.
I wanted to see the ghats, sit by the Ganga, take pictures, explore those tiny lanes, and probably eat more than I should. In my head, it was going to be one of those days I would remember for a long time.
And it was.
Just... not for the reason I expected.
We got onto an engine boat, and the kewat started taking us around the ghats.
From the river, Banaras looked almost unreal.
One ghat after another appeared in front of us. People were bathing in the Ganga, some were praying, some were taking photographs, some were simply sitting there as if they had nowhere else to be.
There was noise everywhere.
And yet, from the middle of the river, it somehow felt peaceful.

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Then the boat reached **Manikarnika Ghat.**

The fire at Manikarnika Ghat never goes out because it is the **Akhand Chita, a sacred cosmic flame believed to have been lit by Lord Shiva himself thousands of years ago .**
It is believed that whoever takes their last breath in Kashi (Banaras) attains *moksha*—freedom from the cycle of birth and rebirth.
Kashi — where even death is celebrated as a festival.
And suddenly, my excitement went quiet.
I saw a body being cremated.
I don't know what exactly happened inside my head at that moment.
I just kept looking.
For almost two minutes, I didn't say anything.
Two minutes is not a very long time.
But sometimes, apparently, it is long enough to make you question the last few months of your life.
Because while I was watching that fire, I suddenly remembered the version of myself from just a few weeks ago.
I had been without a job for almost a month.
And honestly?
I had made it a much bigger deal than it probably was.

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I was applying everywhere. Checking emails constantly. Thinking about my future at 2 a.m. Replaying conversations in my head. Comparing myself with people who seemed to be moving ahead while I was still waiting for my turn.

I had given myself a full-time job of **overthinking.**

Then, just three days before coming to Banaras, I received an offer letter.

I accepted it.

Problem solved, right?

Apparently not.

Because looking there at Manikarnika, I realised something slightly uncomfortable.

The thing that had kept me awake for weeks had already become a thing of the past.

And how many such things have I already worried about?

How many times have I thought, *"If this doesn't happen, I'm finished"*?

And then life happened anyway.

Maybe that's why Manikarnika is different.

It doesn't scream a lesson at you.

It just shows you something you already know but conveniently forget:

Everything ends.

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The person whose body was burning there could have been someone with a huge business.

Maybe he had a house worth crores.

Maybe he had spent his entire life eating at expensive restaurants, travelling the world and collecting things he once thought he could never live without.

And perhaps, somewhere nearby, another person was being cremated who had spent his entire life doing daily-wage work.

Maybe he had sometimes gone to sleep hungry.

Maybe there were nights when he saved half his food for the next morning.

Their lives could not have been more different.

Their bank balances could not have been more different.

Their struggles could not have been more different.

But that fire brought them to the same level.

No VIP entry.

No special treatment.

No negotiation.

No *"but I worked so hard."*

Nothing.

Just the same ending.

And weirdly, I didn't find that thought depressing.

I found it liberating.

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Because if the ending is something I cannot control anyway, why am I spending so much of my life being terrified of everything before it?

Why am I treating one rejection like the end of my career?

Why am I treating one bad month like the end of my life?

Why am I panicking about a future that hasn't even happened yet?

Maybe I don't need to know every turn the river is going to take.

That thought reminded me of the boat.

We chose to get on it.

But once we were inside, we weren't exactly in charge.

The kewat told us where to sit, and we sat.

He changed the direction, and we followed.

He knew the river better than we did, so we trusted him.

We had a choice about getting into the boat.

But we didn't control the river.

Maybe life is exactly like that.

We choose our careers.

We choose the people we love.

We choose whether to take an opportunity.

We work hard.

We make plans.

We sometimes make the wrong decisions and sometimes, surprisingly, the right ones.

But after that?

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There is always something beyond us.

Call it destiny.

Call it God.

Call it the universe.

Call it whatever makes sense to you.

I just call it **that divine power which quietly reminds us that we are not in complete control.**

And maybe that's not something to be afraid of.

Maybe that's where peace begins.

I think that is what I carried back from Manikarnika that day.

Not sadness.

Not fear of death.

Something much simpler.

Perspective.

Because sometimes we are so busy protecting our little world that we forget how temporary it is.

We spend years building an identity around a job, a relationship, money, appearance, achievements, followers, degrees, titles...

And then one day, life reminds us:

Relax. You are a human being, not a permanent resident.

I know that sounds a little harsh.

But maybe we need to hear it.

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So now, whenever I feel scared about something, I remember Manikarnika.

Not because I want to think about death.

But because I want to remember **how alive I actually am.**

When a rejection hurts, I remember the fire.

When I overthink my future, I remember the river.

When I become too attached to something I cannot control, I remember that boat.

And somehow, the noise in my head becomes quieter.

I tell myself—

Do your part.

Apply for the job.

Study for the exam.

Take the chance.

Love people.

Build things.

Travel.

Dream ridiculously big.

But don't let the fear of losing something stop you from enjoying the time you have with it.

Because maybe the point was never to control the journey.

Maybe the point was to **experience it while you're on the boat.**

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And honestly, whenever life scares me now, I have a strange little prescription for myself:

Remember Manikarnika.

Remember that the person who had everything and the person who had almost nothing were eventually brought to the same level by the same divine power.

Remember that your biggest problem today may look ridiculously small a few years from now.

Remember that the river was flowing long before you arrived—and it will keep flowing long after you leave.

And then...

breathe.

Maybe that's all I need sometimes.

Because perhaps the real lesson of Manikarnika isn't that we are all going to die.

We already know that.

Perhaps it is this:

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Since you know the ending, stop being so afraid of the chapters in between.

And maybe that is why, even today, whenever fear gets too loud in my head, I close my eyes and remember that fire.

For a few seconds, everything becomes quiet.

As if I left my worries there, and the Ganga carried the rest away.

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LETTER - 02

ON NOT BECOMING SOMEONE ELSE

Have you ever tried to change yourself just because someone misunderstood you?

When I was a child, my relatives often called me “seedhi.”

Maybe because I didn't get into much mischief. Maybe because I listened to my elders and rarely argued. To them, I was the simple, obedient child.

But in my family, *simple* didn't exactly mean innocent. It could also mean naive, too simple, or even foolish.

I didn't understand that distinction when I was little. I only knew that the word didn't make me feel very special.

Things changed when I reached fifth grade.

I started observing people more closely. I noticed that the children who talked back were often called *smart*. Those who refused to listen

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were considered *clever*, and those who behaved a little rudely were somehow seen as confident.

I began wondering if being well-behaved was actually making people underestimate me.

So I decided to try something new.

I thought, *"Maybe I'll become a little clever. Maybe then they'll stop thinking I'm so simple."*

It wasn't a dramatic transformation. I simply started saying no sometimes, arguing a little, and behaving in ways I normally wouldn't.

Then came one particular day.

My Nani asked me to fill the cooler with water. I was busy doing something else, so I said,

"I'll do it later. I'm doing something right now."

A little later, I heard her telling everyone,

"Dekho, aaj kal kitni chalak ho gayi hai."

And strangely, I felt happy.

For a moment, I thought I had finally succeeded.

I had gone from *simple* to *clever*.

But the excitement didn't last.

Once I was alone, I began wondering why that small comment had made me so happy.

What had I actually achieved?

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I hadn't suddenly become smarter. I hadn't discovered some hidden strength. I had simply behaved differently because I wanted people to change their opinion of me.

And that realization stayed with me.

As I grew older, I began noticing how quickly we put people into categories.

A quiet person becomes *boring*.

A kind person becomes *naive*.

An emotional person becomes *weak*.

A confident person becomes *arrogant*.

We rarely take enough time to understand what exists behind these labels.

Sometimes, we don't even realize that our opinion of someone is based more on our expectations than on the person themselves.

And I realized I had made the same mistake—but with myself.

I had started seeing myself through other people's eyes.

If they thought being obedient meant being foolish, I wanted to become rebellious.

If they thought being soft-spoken meant being weak, I wanted to become louder.

I was trying to correct an image of me that existed in someone else's mind.

But why?

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There is a difference between changing because you are growing and changing because you are seeking approval.
The first one makes you stronger.
The second slowly makes you lose track of yourself.
You can learn to speak up without becoming rude.
You can become confident without becoming arrogant.
You can become independent without losing your kindness.
Growing up doesn't require you to throw away the qualities that made you who you are.
It requires you to understand which qualities are genuinely yours—and which ones you adopted simply because you were trying to please someone.
Today, when I think about that little girl, I don't wish she had been more *clever*.
I actually like that she was *simple*.
She was respectful. She was well-mannered. She didn't feel the need to create a scene to prove that she had a personality.
And today, I can say that I am proud of those qualities.
Not because I want to prove anyone wrong, but because I finally understand their value myself.
Maybe the problem was never that I was too simple.
Maybe the definition of "smart" around me was simply too narrow.
We all experience some version of this while growing up.

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Someone tells us we're too quiet, so we become louder.
Someone calls us boring, so we start performing for attention.
Someone says we're too sensitive, so we stop expressing what we feel.
Someone thinks we're not ambitious enough, so we begin chasing goals that don't even belong to us.
And after doing this for long enough, we can forget what our natural self even looked like.
That's why I think there is something powerful about being able to say:
“This is who I am, and I don't need to become someone else to make you understand me.”
Not everyone will understand you.
Some people will judge you from a distance. Some will misunderstand your silence, your kindness, your choices, or even your personality.
But that doesn't automatically mean you need fixing.
Sometimes, the person looking at you simply doesn't have the right perspective.
I don't think we should become stubborn about who we are either. If someone genuinely points out a flaw, we should have the courage to look at it.
But there is a difference between constructive criticism and someone else's limited perception of you.
One helps you grow.

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The other makes you doubt yourself.

Learn to know the difference.

Because if you keep changing every time someone misunderstands you, you'll eventually become a collection of other people's expectations.

And I don't think that's what life is supposed to be.

Life should give you the freedom to discover yourself—not constantly redesign yourself for an audience.

So, if someone calls you *simple*, *too quiet*, *too emotional*, *too different*, or anything else, pause before you decide that you need to change.

Ask yourself:

"Do I really want to change this about myself, or do I simply want them to see me differently?"

That question can save you from years of pretending.

Moral :

Don't change your identity to correct someone else's misunderstanding of you.

Change when it helps you grow. Stay when something is genuinely yours.

Because sometimes, you don't need to become a better version for the world.

You simply need to become comfortable being the version of yourself that was never wrong to begin with.

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LETTER - 03
ON LEAVING WHAT NO LONGER VALUES YOU

Sometimes the bravest career decision is not accepting an opportunity, but walking away from one.

Dear me,

I want to take you back to the time when you thought your career had finally begun.

You had joined your **first internship**.

And God, you were happy.

You had just entered your final year of college. After all those applications, interviews, waiting, and rejections, you finally had something to put after your name.

Intern.

It wasn't a big company. It wasn't even a paid internship.

But at that moment, none of that mattered enough.

When you came back after the interview, you were already smiling.

And when the result came—

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Selected.

It felt bigger than it actually was.

You thought, *"Okay. This is it. Maybe my career is finally starting."*

There was just one small disappointment.

It was unpaid.

You would be working, learning, giving your time and energy, but there would be no stipend at the end of the month.

Still, you told yourself,

"It's okay. After so many rejections, at least I got something. Paid or unpaid, it's an internship."

Sometimes, when you've been rejected enough times, **even an opportunity that doesn't value you can feel like a blessing.**

You don't ask whether it's good for you.

You're just relieved that someone finally said yes.

Your joining date was the very next day.

You told your family.

You went.

And on the first day, there wasn't much to do except read and understand things.

It felt normal.

New company.

New people.

New environment.

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New version of you.

You were excited to learn.

And then the tasks started coming.

You did them.

Then you did more.

And then a little more.

You didn't just complete your work.

You gave it everything.

If something was assigned to you, you wanted it done properly.

Sometimes you'd continue working on Sunday because you thought maybe, just maybe, when Monday came, someone would notice.

Maybe someone would say,

"Good work."

Maybe someone would appreciate the extra effort.

Maybe someone would finally know your name.

But there is a strange kind of tiredness that doesn't come from working too much.

It comes from **working hard and feeling invisible.**

You could skip lunch.

You could stay late.

You could finish something before the deadline.

You could put your entire Sunday into a task.

And still, if nobody cared, the work began to feel strangely empty.

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It was never really about the money.

You already knew the internship was unpaid.

You had accepted that.

What you hadn't expected was the absence of appreciation.

Because when you are working for someone else, you need something to tell you that your effort matters.

Sometimes it's money.

Sometimes it's recognition.

Sometimes it's simply a,

"I noticed."

You weren't getting any of them.

At first, you blamed yourself.

You thought,

Maybe I'm new.

Maybe I don't understand corporate culture yet.

Maybe this is just how internships work.

And perhaps that is how we tolerate things longer than we should.

We keep giving a situation new explanations because accepting the truth would mean making a difficult decision.

You started calling it **corporate culture**.

Maybe this was normal.

Maybe this was toxicity.

Maybe everyone just worked like this.

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And then there were the moments that made you question reality altogether.

Imagine having a non-technical CEO tell you,

“If ChatGPT isn't working, why don't you build your own?”

You would sit there trying to process it.

Your blood would boil like a pressure cooker.

But then you'd remember—

You're an intern.

So you swallowed it.

You completed the task.

You moved on.

Because sometimes your position makes you feel like you're not allowed to question things.

Then came the CEO's birthday party.

You were invited.

And honestly, you didn't want to go.

Not because you hated anyone.

You just wondered—

Why should I be there?

The CEO barely knew you.

Whether you attended or didn't attend probably wouldn't change anything.

But HR insisted.

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So you went.

And that's when you noticed something almost funny.

Nobody really seemed interested in whose birthday it was.

Everyone was busy with the food.

The party.

The samosas.

And you stood there thinking—

How strange are we sometimes?

We imagine that someone is happy because of *us*, when sometimes they're simply happy because there's food in front of them.

Maybe that's life too.

We often mistake someone's presence around us for appreciation.

They're there.

They're smiling.

They're saying something nice.

And we assume—

They must value me.

But sometimes, they're just there because there's a samosa on the table.

Still, you stayed.

Not because you were happy.

Because you had **hope.**

That little word can make people tolerate almost anything.

You thought that maybe after three months, things would change.

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Maybe they would offer you a full-time position.

Maybe all these difficult days would eventually become worth it.

Maybe this internship would become the beginning you had imagined.

So you held on.

You kept thinking,

Just a little longer.

And perhaps that was the hardest part.

Not leaving.

Knowing that you should leave, but still having a reason to stay.

Then came the day when something inside you finally snapped.

New interns joined.

Some of them were less experienced than you.

Less qualified.

And yet, they were being paid.

You weren't.

That was the moment it stopped being about money.

It became about **fairness.**

You went to HR.

And instead of getting a straightforward answer, you felt like you were being taken around in circles.

That day, something became very clear.

You weren't confused anymore.

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You weren't being impatient.

You weren't failing to understand corporate culture.

You were simply in the wrong place.

And for the first time, you thought,

Enough.

Not because you suddenly became fearless.

You were still scared.

You wondered whether you would find another internship.

You wondered what you would tell your family.

You wondered whether leaving something was worse than staying somewhere you didn't belong.

But sometimes, courage doesn't arrive before the decision.

Sometimes, courage is what comes after you make it.

And you resigned.

I know it sounds easy when written in a few paragraphs.

It wasn't.

Leaving an opportunity you've fought hard to get is terrifying.

Especially when you have spent months believing that this might be your only chance.

But you had something many people forget to carry into their careers:

a family that didn't make you feel like failure was the end of the world.

Your family supported you.

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And your father's courage gave you the final push you needed.

So you left.

Not with another offer waiting.

Not with certainty.

Just with the quiet belief that **you deserved better than staying somewhere that made you question your worth.**

And then, months later, you went to Mussoorie.

You were standing there, looking at the mountains.

The air was cold.

The sky felt wider.

Everything was quiet in that particular way mountains are quiet—not empty, but peaceful.

And suddenly, you remembered the internship.

The pressure.

The confusion.

The constant questioning.

The fear of resigning.

And then you looked at the mountains again.

You smiled.

Because from there, everything seemed so much smaller.

And you realized something.

Maybe our problems are not always as big as we make them.

Sometimes, we stand so close to a problem that all we can see is its size.

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We forget that there is a world beyond it.

We forget that there are other companies.

Other opportunities.

Other people.

Other versions of ourselves.

We forget that life doesn't end because one door closes.

But there was something else you understood that day.

Our problems can be like mountains too.

The difference is—

Mussoorie's mountains are beautiful to look at.

Some of the mountains we create in our minds are not.

They are made of fear.

Overthinking.

Self-doubt.

What if I don't get another job?

What if I made the wrong decision?

What will people say?

What if this was my only opportunity?

And sometimes, we spend months sitting at the bottom of these mountains, terrified of climbing them.

When all we really need is to take one step away.

That day, looking at Mussoorie, I understood why leaving had felt so difficult.

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I had been standing inside the problem.

I couldn't see how toxic it had become because I was busy surviving it.

But distance does something beautiful.

It gives you perspective.

The same situation that once felt like the end of your career looked completely different from a quiet mountain.

And maybe that's what we need sometimes.

Not an immediate solution.

Just enough distance to breathe.

Dear me,

Remember this whenever you find yourself trapped somewhere that makes you feel small.

Remember the mountains.

Remember how peaceful they looked once you were far enough away from everything that had been overwhelming you.

And remember—

you were only one decision away from leaving.

Not every difficult situation requires you to stay and prove your strength.

Sometimes strength is knowing when your energy is being wasted.

Sometimes growth looks like accepting an opportunity.

And sometimes growth looks like **resigning from it.**

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You don't have to hold on to something simply because you worked hard to get it.

You are allowed to say,

"This isn't for me anymore."

You are allowed to start again.

You are allowed to choose yourself.

Because an internship is just an internship.

A job is just a job.

A company is just a company.

None of them are your entire life.

Maybe that's what Mussoorie gave me that day.

Not an answer.

Just perspective.

The mountains didn't solve my problems.

They simply reminded me that my problems were not the whole landscape.

And perhaps that's the lesson.

Don't let one bad chapter convince you that the entire book is going to be bad.

Sometimes you are not stuck.

You are simply standing too close to the mountain.

Take a step back.

Breathe.

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Look again.

And if the place you are standing in no longer feels right—

leave.

There will be another road.

Another city.

Another opportunity.

Another version of you waiting somewhere ahead.

And maybe one day, you'll look back at the thing you were once terrified to leave and wonder:

"Why did I think my life would end there?"

Just like I did.

Standing in Mussoorie.

Looking at the mountains.

Finally understanding that some decisions are beautiful not because they are easy—

but because they set you free.

With love,

Me

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LETTER - 04
TO THE ONE WHO LOVED ME, AND TO THE ONE WHO COULDN'T

Some love stories are not meant to end together. Some are simply meant to be remembered.

Dear me,

I want to tell you about him.

Slowly, this time.

Not the version of the story that fits neatly into a beginning, middle, and end. Not the version where someone falls in love, confesses, gets a yes, and everything suddenly makes sense.

I want to tell you the version that actually happened.

The one that stayed unfinished.

The one that took me years to understand.

The Bus Stop

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It was a winter evening.

The kind where the sun disappears before you are ready for the day to end.

Everyone was standing at the bus stop with their bags on the ground, talking about random things, checking their phones, laughing at jokes that weren't even that funny. Someone's phone was playing a song nobody had chosen.

One by one, the buses came.

One by one, people left.

"Bye."

"See you tomorrow."

"Text me when you reach."

And slowly, the crowd became smaller.

Until there were only two of us.

She looked at the road.

No bus.

He looked at his phone.

Then put it away.

He looked at her.

Looked away.

Looked again.

There was something about the silence that evening. Maybe the cold. Maybe the fact that we both knew time was running out.

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Finally, he spoke.

Softly.

“Want to say something.”

She looked at him.

“Haan, bolo.”

He looked down at his shoes. There was a small smile on his face, the kind people wear when they are trying to hide what they are actually thinking.

Then he looked up.

“Do you know something..? Kuch khabaar hai??”

Her heart skipped.

“Kya?”

He smiled.

“Yahi ki bus aa gayi hai.”

She turned around.

The bus was right there.

Waiting.

“Oh... haan. Chalo.”

And just like that, the moment was gone.

They got on the bus.

Nothing had happened.

Not really.

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If someone had been standing beside us, they probably wouldn't have noticed anything.

But I was watching from inside.

And something had happened.

Not in the words.

In the knowing.

I knew now that I knew.

I just didn't know what to do with that knowledge.

So I did what most people do when something scares them.

I ignored it.

Maybe I was imagining things.

Maybe he was just being himself.

Maybe it would stay this way forever.

A little confusing.

A little beautiful.

A little unfinished.

It almost did.

There Was Someone Else

There had been someone else.

Before him.

Or maybe somewhere in between him and me.

Someone who was never really mine.

I told him about that person.

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Everything.

The small things.

The stupid things.

The things that didn't even make sense to me.

And he listened.

Every single time.

I never stopped to wonder what it must have felt like for him.

To listen to the girl you love talk about someone else.

To answer her questions.

To comfort her.

To pretend that you were only a friend when your heart was asking for something more.

Maybe that was his way of loving me.

Not by asking for a place in my life.

But by staying there anyway.

I still don't know how he did it.

And maybe I never will.

Four Years

Some people enter your life loudly.

You remember the exact moment they arrived.

Others don't.

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They become part of your ordinary days so quietly that you don't notice how important they have become until you imagine those days without them.

He was the second kind.

Four years.

Four years of conversations, jokes, arguments, stupid moments, shared silence, and ordinary days that didn't feel important while they were happening.

There was no dramatic declaration.

No movie scene.

No grand gesture.

Just a boy who somehow kept choosing the same person.

Me.

And a girl who was too busy living her own story to understand that someone else was quietly writing her into his.

Maybe that's what makes one-sided love so strange.

One person experiences it as a love story.

The other experiences it as life.

And both are telling the truth.

Then came the day everyone had been pretending wasn't coming.

Farewell.

Everyone wore their best clothes.

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People signed each other's shirts.

Photos were taken over and over again because apparently one hundred pictures were necessary to prove that we had been happy.

Some people were crying.

Some were laughing at the people who were crying.

Everyone kept saying the same things.

"We'll stay in touch."

"We'll definitely meet again."

"Nothing will change."

We all knew that wasn't completely true.

Some things always change when a chapter ends.

That day, by coincidence, he and I were wearing the same colour.

Everyone noticed.

Everyone teased us.

We laughed.

Because sometimes laughing is easier than explaining something you don't even understand yourself.

Later, in the middle of all that noise, I looked at him.

He was laughing with everyone else.

Nothing on his face gave anything away.

And I remember thinking:

Does he know that I know?

Neither of us said anything.

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Maybe some questions are too frightening to ask when you already suspect the answer.

Signature Day

Then came the last day.

The actual last day.

Everyone was busy signing shirts, taking pictures, writing messages that were supposed to last forever.

He was standing a little away from everyone.

Not sad.

Just quiet.

I walked towards him.

"Hey, why are you standing here?"

He looked at me.

Then hesitated.

"Can I get your few minutes?"

Something about his voice made me stop.

"Haan... aise kyun bol raha hai?"

"Nahi, aise koi baat nahi hai."

But this time, I knew.

There was a reason.

He stepped away from the crowd.

I followed.

Perhaps he had rehearsed this moment in his head.

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And when it finally came, he didn't make it complicated.

He simply asked:

“Have you felt anything for me?”

I didn't answer immediately.

Instead, I asked him,

“Do you know my story?”

“Yes I Know.”

I looked at him.

“Phir bhi?”

He smiled.

Softly.

Almost sadly.

“Haan... phir bhi.”

Two words.

No accusation.

No *“but why?”*

No *“what did he have that I didn't?”*

Just—

Phir bhi.

I think that was the purest part of it.

He knew.

And he still loved me.

He knew the answer might hurt him.

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And he still wanted to hear it.

“Mujhe haan ya na mein jawab dena,” he said.

I was scared.

Not of him.

Of what my answer might do to us.

So I asked,

“Will my answer change our friendship ?”

He smiled.

“I already know your answer. But please tell me anyway... just once. Just so my heart can be at peace.”

I didn't understand how he could already know the answer and still need me to say it.

Maybe that's what closure is.

Sometimes the heart knows.

It just wants the person to say it out loud.

He looked at me.

“Say...”

I took a breath.

And said the hardest simple word.

“I can't do this. I can't forget him, and I can't replace him. I know he is gone from my life, but I still can't forget him... What would you do if you were me?"

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That's all.
No long explanation.
No beautiful speech.
Just one sentence that could close a story I had never even known I was part of.
There was silence.
A very long silence.

The environment was silent—so quiet that I could hear the sound of the wind in my ears.

There was a faint smile on his face, one I know I will never forget.

Breaking the silence, he said,
“Come on, we have to take some pictures.”

Tears filled my eyes.

He looked at me and said,
“Come on,. Are you not going to listen to me now?”

And then he said something I would remember for years.
“Isse kya farak padta hai? Kuch farak nahi padega. Main jo kal tha, aaj bhi wahi hoon... aur hamesha rahunga.”

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I thought that was enough.

It wasn't.

After a pause, he said quietly,

"Bas... meri bhi life mein ab koi aur nahi aa payega."

Almost a whisper.

He wasn't asking me to feel guilty.

He wasn't trying to change my answer.

He wasn't even asking me to stay.

He was simply leaving behind one last truth.

And I didn't know what to do with it.

Around us, everything continued.

Someone called my name for a photograph.

Someone wanted me to sign their shirt.

People were laughing.

The day was moving forward as if nothing had happened.

But something had.

The silence between us finally had a name.

Maybe That Was Love Too

For a long time, I wondered whether I should feel guilty.

After all, someone had loved me for years.

And I couldn't love him back.

But with time, I understood something.

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Not being able to love someone back doesn't make you cruel.

And loving someone who cannot love you back doesn't make your love meaningless.

Love is not always a transaction.

You don't love someone only because you are certain they will choose you.

Sometimes you love them because something about them made your heart feel something it had never felt before.

And sometimes, the bravest thing love can do is accept a *no* without turning it into punishment.

He could have made me feel guilty.

He could have blamed me.

He could have walked away angrily.

Instead, he simply said,

"I'm still me."

And somehow, that stayed with me more than the confession itself.

Maybe that's why one-sided love is so difficult to explain.

Because from the outside, people see the obvious question:

"If you didn't end up together, what was the point?"

But perhaps that isn't the right question.

Because not every beautiful thing exists to be possessed.

A sunset is beautiful even though you cannot keep it.

A song can mean everything to you even though it ends.

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A childhood can shape you even though you can never go back to it.
So why must love be different?
Why must love only be considered real if it ends with *"and they lived happily ever after"*?
Maybe some love stories are beautiful precisely because they remain unfinished.

And Then I Understood

I once thought a successful love story was one where two people ended up together.
Now I'm not so sure.
Maybe sometimes the victory is simply having loved someone genuinely.
Maybe sometimes the person doesn't stay.
Maybe the relationship never gets a name.
Maybe there is no ***"us."***
And still, something real existed.
Something that changed you.
Something you carried forward.
Something you remember years later when a particular winter evening, a bus stop, a colour, a song, or even a random sentence takes you back to a moment you thought you had forgotten.
And perhaps that is what he became for me.
Not my unfinished relationship.

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Not my missed opportunity.

Just a beautiful part of my past that I didn't know was beautiful until it was over.

So what if he couldn't be yours?

What does that take away from the fact that, once upon a time, someone loved you enough to wait, listen, understand, and finally accept your truth without making you feel guilty for it?

And what is love, really, if you never had to miss someone?

If you could simply forget them the moment they walked away, was it ever deep enough to leave a mark?

Maybe love isn't always about getting the person.

Maybe sometimes it's about carrying the feeling.

Because if you got everything you wanted, perhaps the story would end there.

But when someone leaves without becoming yours, the story continues somewhere else—

inside you.

And maybe that's where the most beautiful love stories live.

Not in photographs.

Not in relationships.

Not in *"we ended up together."*

But in the quiet places of your memory where someone still exists exactly as they were.

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I don't know what he feels today.

Maybe he has moved on.

Maybe someday he will meet someone and love her differently.

Maybe I will become nothing more than an old chapter in his life.

And that's okay.

I don't need to know.

Because his love was never beautiful because it belonged to me.

It was beautiful because **it existed.**

And my answer was never cruel because it was honest.

Maybe that is the lesson I needed from all of this:

You can be loved deeply and still not be able to love someone back.

You can say no and still respect what they felt.

You can lose someone without anyone being the villain.

And sometimes, two people can leave the same conversation carrying completely different things—

one carrying an answer,

the other carrying a memory.

Neither is wrong.

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Dear me,

If you ever think about him again, don't turn the story into a tragedy.

Don't ask yourself what could have happened.

Don't create an alternate ending just because the real one wasn't what stories usually promise.

Remember the bus.

Remember the winter.

Remember the same-coloured clothes.

Remember the last conversation.

Remember the way he said *"phir bhi."*

And remember that, for years, someone quietly found something in you worth loving.

You didn't have to become his.

And he didn't have to become yours.

Some people come into our lives not to stay, but to leave behind a feeling we didn't know we were capable of carrying.

Maybe he was that person for me.

Too Young To Know :)

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A love I couldn't accept in the way he wanted—

but a love I can still acknowledge for what it was.

Real.

Quiet.

Unreturned.

And somehow...

beautiful.

With love,

Me

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Conclusion

Maybe I was too young to know what life would ask of me.

Too young to understand why some dreams take longer than others.
Too young to know that being left behind is sometimes just another way of being redirected.
To understand that people can love you and still not stay.
Too young to know that some goodbyes don't come with closure, and some questions don't come with answers.

For a long time, I thought growing up meant figuring everything out.

Getting the job.
Making your parents proud.
Becoming independent.
Knowing where you're going.
Knowing who you're becoming.

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But somewhere along the way, I realized

Maybe growing up isn't about having all the answers.

Maybe it's about learning to live with the questions.

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